



Sanjay Nayak receiving CSIR Award

The gold medal of an almost IITian

A nonchalant all-rounder, young Sanjay was poised to enter the next stage of life with his sights set on the IITs. However, life had other plans. Due to a mix-up, he arrived an hour late for the second paper of the IIT exam, which impacted his overall performance despite a strong showing in the first paper. “Although I did well in the first paper, it affected my overall performance. Nevertheless, I got into other institutes and eventually went to Birla Institute of Technology (BIT) in Ranchi,” he says.

This setback did not deter Sanjay. Determined to make the most of his situation, he found that with effort, he could excel. “In the first semester at BIT, I realised that with some effort, I could excel,” he says. Guns, swords, gangs, fights—Bihar in the early 80s was quite turbulent after the JP movement, but for Sanjay, academics and sports kept him going. “It was like the Wild West where you saw and experienced things that toughened you up—nothing in life could scare me after that. Despite the chaos, the academic environment was supportive, and the whole experience at BIT was very

holistic, combining academics with sports and other activities,” he recalls with a secret smile.

By the time he graduated, he was the gold medallist of the institute, having achieved the highest marks

across all branches by a significant margin. This experience strengthened his confidence in the fact that he could excel wherever he was, “even if I didn’t get into IIT,” he shares.

Instead of opting for a conventional job, Sanjay sought broader horizons and pursued an MS in computer engineering at North Carolina State University, Raleigh. Adapting to a new cultural and academic environment, he faced initial challenges but gradually gained skills and confidence. “I figured that I had to learn a lot in a short time. To do that I needed to make smart decisions, optimise my time, and plan my study, to input maximum knowledge in the least time. I managed to crack the time management code and was able to tackle new challenges, figure things out independently and excel academically,” he shares. Years later, it was a pleasant surprise for Sanjay when North Carolina State University decided to induct him into



Sanjay Nayak at the time of IPO